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A few months ago we launched a radio channel solely for women which is quite appropriately called 'Meow'. The channel has a talk format and they have a late night programme called 'Between the Sheets' which has women talking about their innermost desires, their sexual fantasies, marital rape, infidelity, the importance of sex in marriage, faking pleasure and other such topics. Every time I listen to it, I am amazed at the frankness and humour with which women from all strata of society talk about their intimate lives. The uniqueness of radio is that it gives you anonymity so you feel free to reveal your real self if you choose to.

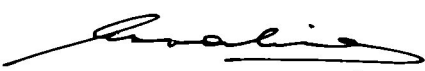
It is apparent that a great change has taken place in the attitude of urban women and it is altering every equation in Indian society, particularly marriage. Every year INDIA TODAY commissions AC Nielsen-ORG-MARG to do a sex survey. This year we have chosen to study sex in marriage as the institution has been under tremendous scrutiny of late, with rising divorce rate and increase in the number of women at the workplace.

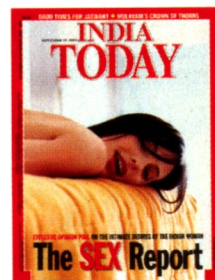
We did our first sex survey five years ago in 2003 and it was greeted in some quarters with outrage and even court cases. It was on Sex and the Indian Woman and for the first time, we had women across 10 cities, big and small, telling us what positions they liked in bed, whether they had one orgasm or many, and what their preference in foreplay was. Subsequently, we studied the sexual habits of Indian men, of the single Indian woman and the single Indian man. The surveys showed the steady progression—and in some cases regression—of sexual desire. Who loved how and who wanted what came pouring out, almost as if it had been waiting to be tapped. The awakening of the Indian woman was a leitmotif. She was willing to talk about what gave her pleasure, whether the man was able to understand or not.

This issue's survey of urban marriage unravels some of the pressures on the institution of work, of children, of family responsibilities, even of aspirations. Most importantly, it focuses on the nature of sex in marriage. Are couples having fun in the bedroom, is sex a domestic chore for the woman, is the man seeking his thrills outside his marriage bed?

Some of the finest minds have tried to analyse what married men and women are trying to say. Psychoanalyst Sudhir Kakar has compared the romantic ideal of Hindi movies to the often grim reality of marriage as a family, rather than individual, institution. Sociologist Rochona Majumdar has analysed the phenomenon of forced sex within marriage, a touchy issue that the women surveyed have not shied away from. Family sociologist Patricia Uberoi has given the survey a historical perspective that even we can't match, by analysing the results of a study conducted by sociologist G.S. Ghurye in 1938.

Apparently our economic miracle is having an effect on our sex lives too. Our essayist Uberoi puts it well: "The economic growth of the nation cannot be matched by an 8 to 10 per cent increase in sexual voracity." Pity.

  
(Aroon Purie)



Our Sept 2003 cover